POSC 3710: European Politics

11/4/2026: THE POPULIST RADICAL RIGHT

DR. WILL HORNE

CLEMSON UNIVERSITY


FRONT
NATIONAL

What is populism?

Cas Mudde, a Dutch political scientist, defines it as

> **"an ideology that considers society to be ultimately separated into two homogeneous and antagonistic groups, 'the pure people' versus 'the corrupt elite', and which argues that politics should be an expression of the volonté générale (general will) of the people."**

Populism is contrasted with two other traditions.

Technocracy/Elitism	PLURALISM
"Populism's mirror-image" – rule by experts (or elites). Follow science/economics rather than what the people want	Society is "a heterogeneous collection of groups and individuals with often fundamentally different views and wishes"

A thin ideology

Populism "can be easily combined with very different (thin and full) other ideologies, including communism, ecologism, nationalism or socialism."

ON THE LEFT: POPULISM WITH SOCIALISM

- The people: the working class, "the 99%"
- The elite: business and the wealthy
- Podemos in Spain, Syriza in Greece, France Unbowed, Bernie Sanders (or the DSA) in the USA

ON THE RIGHT: POPULISM WITH NATIVISM

- The people: the native-born; sometimes narrower, the "real" citizens
- The elite: "traitors to the nation," the media, "globalists," intellectuals; historically, Jews
- The National Rally in France, the AfD in Germany, the PVV in the Netherlands, (parts of) MAGA in the USA

First waves of populism associated with the left – William Jennings Bryan in the USA and Latin American populism.

POPULIST OR NOT? ROUND 1 OF 3

“This will be a victory for real people, a victory for ordinary people, a victory for decent people.”



Nigel Farage

Leader of the UK Independence Party, at 4 a.m. on June 24, 2016, as Britain voted to leave the EU

POPULIST

Leave won 52% to 48%. If the winners are the real people, what are the other 48%?

“It is the establishment versus the people and it is our historic duty to make sure that the people prevail.”



Jeremy Corbyn

Leader of Britain’s Labour Party, opening his election campaign on April 20, 2017

POPULIST, ON THE LEFT

The same two camps. The elite here is economic: “a rigged system set up by the wealth extractors.”

POPULIST OR NOT? ROUND 3 OF 3

“We all know what to do, but we don’t know how to get re-elected once we have done it.”



Jean-Claude Juncker

Prime minister of Luxembourg and chair of the euro zone’s finance ministers, on economic reform, 2007

NOT POPULIST: ELITIST

The leaders know what is right, and the voters are the obstacle. Mudde calls elitism populism’s mirror image.

Why “Radical”?

- A radical version of views the mainstream also holds
  - Most parties now want less immigration and stronger borders
  - Radical: remove immigrants whatever their legal status; ignore asylum law
- Hostile to parts of liberal democracy: a free press, pluralism
  - Orban referred to “Illiberal Democracy”
- They accept elections, and want fewer limits on whoever wins
  - More recently, challenge legitimacy of results and claim corruption

Core feature: nativism

NATIVISM

Mudde, in a later book: “an ideology which holds that states should be inhabited exclusively by members of the native group (‘the nation’) and that nonnative elements (persons and ideas) are fundamentally threatening to the homogeneous nation-state”

- Often the aim is a state with one culture
- The charge against the elite: it sold the country out to foreigners

Before the click: what does this poster say, and about whom?



The Swiss People’s Party, 2009, against letting Bulgarians and Romanians work in Switzerland. Its campaign chief: “The ravens are aggressive, cunning and devious.”

The Swiss People’s Party is the largest party in Switzerland: 27.9% in 2023, and two of the seven seats in the government.

Core feature: nativism, two more campaigns

Before the click: what does this one say?



2007: THE BLACK SHEEP

- White sheep kick a black sheep off the Swiss flag
- The slogan: “Create security”

2011: KOSOVARS

- Its advertisement: “Kosovars slash the Swiss”
- Two party officials were convicted of racial discrimination

Both are campaigns of the Swiss People’s Party, the largest party in Switzerland.

ACTIVITY

From today's reading: Gidron and Hall

Economics or culture?

1 **ECONOMICS**

"On site, 90% of them are Polish. They will put in a quote for a pittance and put in ten times more hours than you."

A Labour voter considering UKIP, Newcastle-under-Lyme

2 **CULTURE**

"People are getting sick and tired that England isn't English. It is immigration, but it's lots of things."

A Labour voter considering UKIP, Newcastle-under-Lyme

3 **BOTH**

"I went to the housing office with my husband to see about a council house and they said 'you've got no chance, we've got to move the immigrants in first'."

A UKIP voter, Thurrock

4 **ECONOMICS**

France: 95% of workers had permanent contracts in 1982, and 86% in 2012. Under 25, fewer than half.

Gidron and Hall

5 **CULTURE**

Britain, 2016: 14% of Leave voters called immigration a force for good. Among Remain voters, 57%.

Gidron and Hall

6 **BOTH**

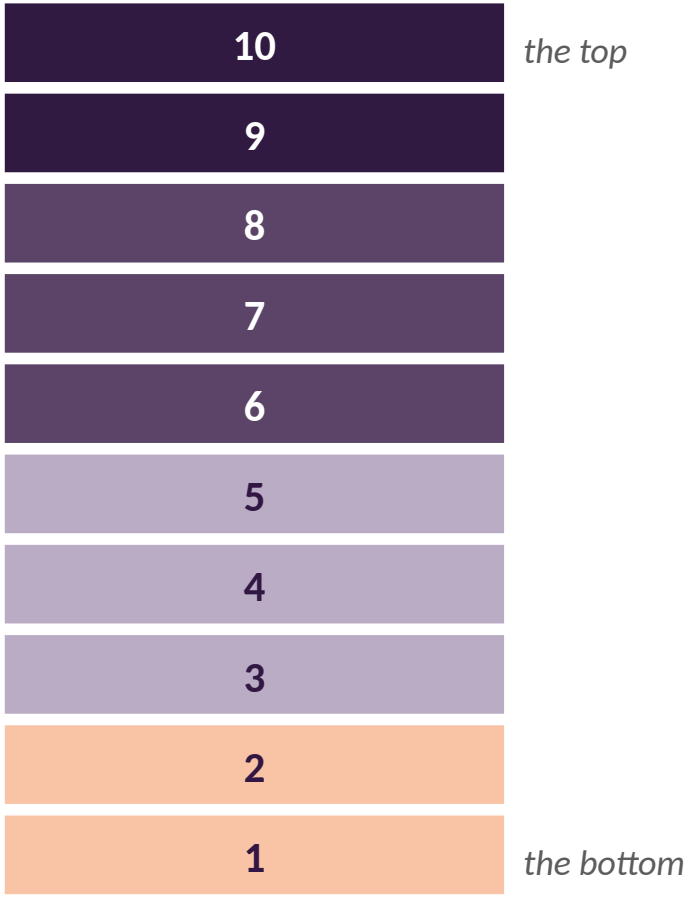
"A policeman told me you can't get promoted now unless you're a certain colour."

A Labour voter considering UKIP, Newcastle-under-Lyme

Gidron and Hall's answer: each of the six is about where the speaker's group stands in society.

The voters' words: focus groups run for Lord Ashcroft, a British pollster, in 2012. UKIP is the UK Independence Party.

Subjective social status: the ladder



THE SURVEY QUESTION

"In our society, some groups are more on top and others are more at the bottom. Thinking about yourself, where would you place yourself in this scale?"

WHAT IT MEASURES

"The level of social respect or esteem people believe is accorded them within the social order."

Asked in the same words in many countries since 1987, so the answers can be compared across countries and over time.

What Gidron and Hall find

6% → 11%

The predicted chance of a vote for the populist right, moving from medium-high to medium-low status

10 of 12

Countries where men without a college degree rank lower, relative to everyone else, than 25 to 30 years earlier

9 of 12

Countries where women's status rose relative to men's over the same years

Their claim is a modest one: status is "one pathway" by which economic and cultural change reach the ballot box.

Two roads to lower status

THE ECONOMIC ROAD

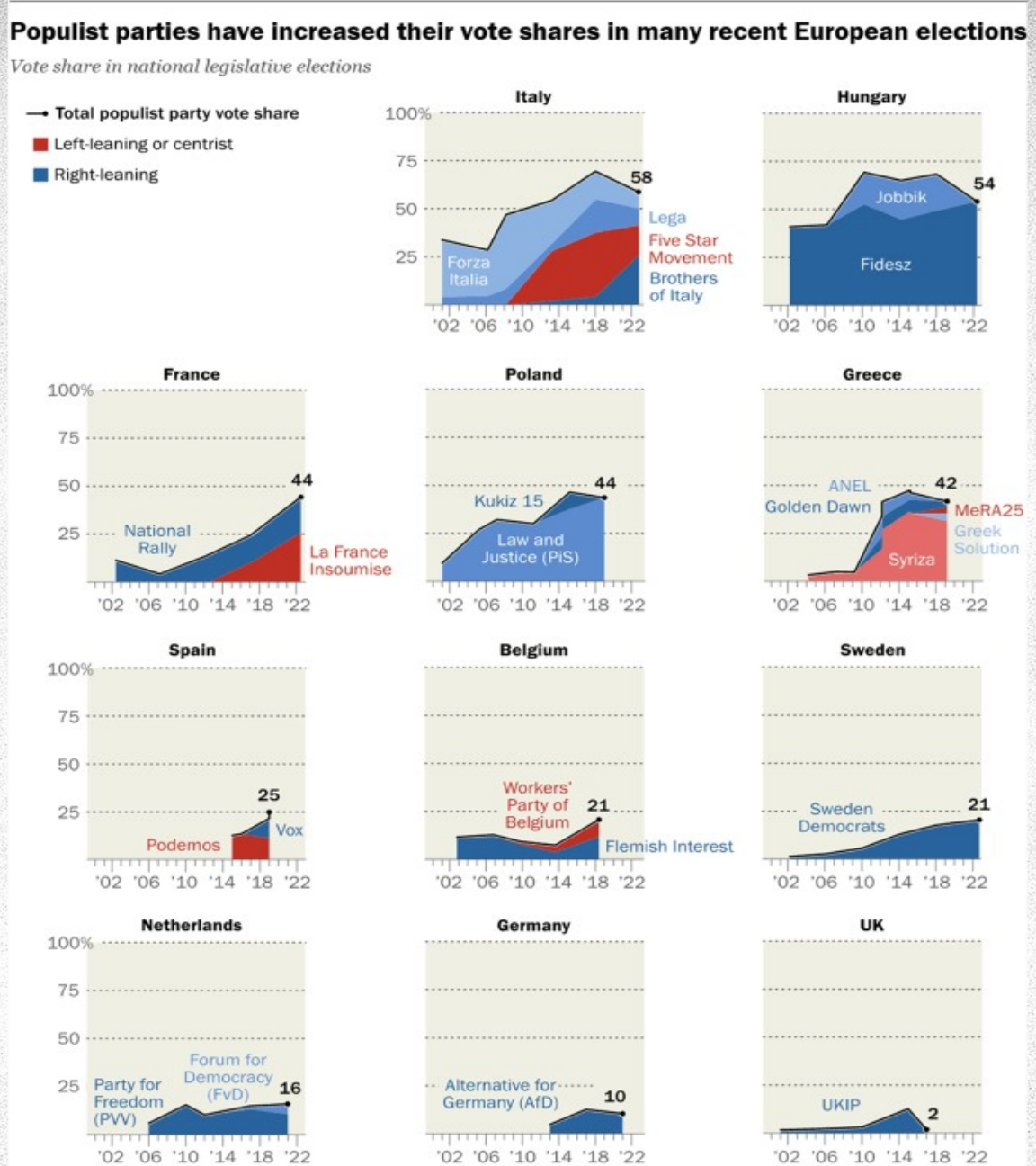
- "The gradual disappearance of low-skilled decent jobs"
- Part-time and temporary work in their place

THE CULTURAL ROAD

- Esteem goes to skills and degrees: "It is no longer enough to be a hard worker."
- Women in paid work, ages 25 to 54: 54% in 1980, 71% in 2010

LOWER STANDING
for people (particularly men) without a college degree

SUPPORT FOR THE POPULIST RIGHT
"Threats to a person's social status evoke feelings of hostility to outgroups."


Populist parties have increased their vote shares in many recent European elections
Vote share in national legislative elections
Total populist party vote share
Left-leaning or centrist
Right-leaning
Italy
100%
75
50
25
58
Lega
Five Star Movement
Brothers of Italy
Forza Italia
'02 '06 '10 '14 '18 '22
Hungary
54
Jobbik
Fidesz
France
44
National Rally
La France Insoumise
Poland
44
Kukiz 15
Law and Justice (PiS)
Greece
42
ANEL
Golden Dawn
MeRA25
Greek Solution
Syriza
Spain
25
Podemos
Vox
Belgium
21
Workers' Party of Belgium
Flemish Interest
Sweden
21
Sweden Democrats
Netherlands
16
Party for Freedom (PVV)
Forum for Democracy (FvD)
Germany
10
Alternative for Germany (AfD)
UK
2
UKIP
Note: Data presented is only for 2000-2022; some of these parties have competed in elections and won vote share for longer than that period. Party list vote is used for Germany; first-round results are used for France. For more on European populist parties, see Appendix.
Source: ParlGov, Swedish Election Authority and the Guardian.
PEW RESEARCH CENTER

Source:
Pew

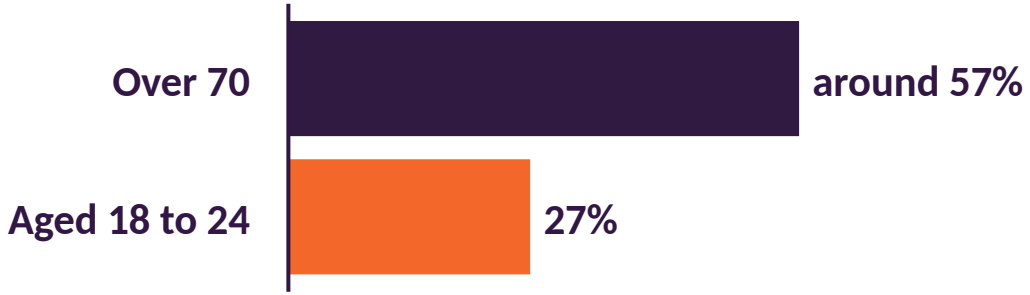
France, April 2022: who votes against the system?

HANDS UP

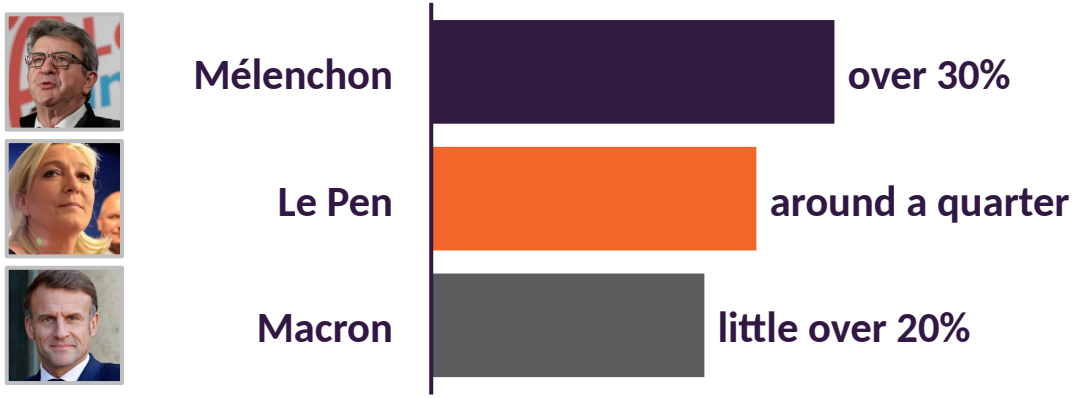
In France, who backs Le Pen more?

Voters over 60 | Voters under 60

Vote for Macron and the other mainstream candidates, first round of the presidential election



Voters under 35: the three leading candidates



Emmanuel Macron, president of France since 2017. Marine Le Pen, of the National Rally, on the radical right. Jean-Luc Mélenchon, of France Unbowed, on the radical left.

The finding: youth predicts a vote against the system, on the left and on the right. Support for the mainstream grows with age.

Education sets the direction

Two 24-year-olds without steady work. One has a degree. Who is the likelier far-right voter?

The graduate

The school leaver

WHY THE YOUNG

- Reforms opened up labor markets and cut social protection, mostly for the young. Rights already earned stayed in place
- “dualization.” Insiders, pensioners above all, keep their protection; outsiders go without
- Most of all in southern Europe; also in Belgium, France, Germany and Austria

WHICH WAY THEY TURN

- In most countries the young prefer the radical left to the far right: Syriza in Greece, Podemos in Spain
- In France, graduates who vote against the establishment lean to Mélenchon. School leavers lean to Le Pen
- “Higher education seems to have a powerful inoculating effect against sympathy for the far right”

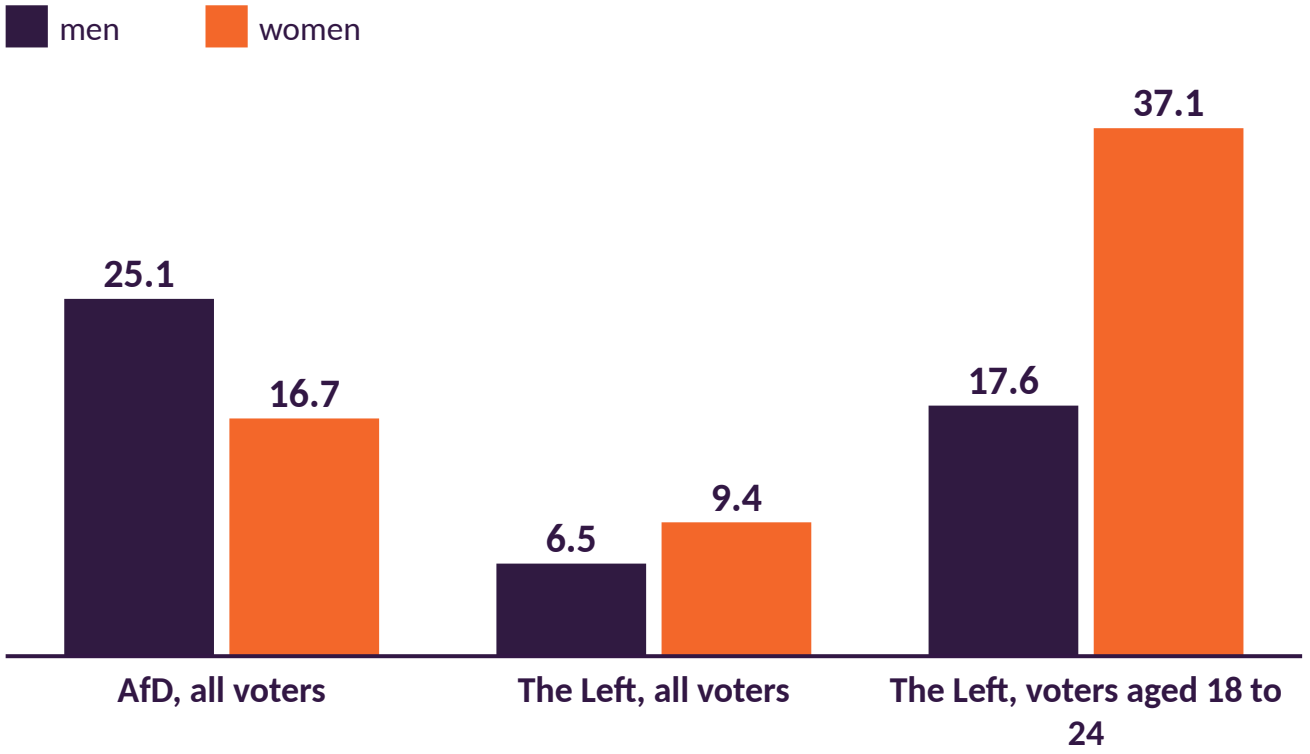
Graduates and less educated voters “share a feeling that things need to change, but disagree on the direction of this change.”

Are these Männerparteien [men's parties]?

THE PATTERN

- The first leaders were all men, and so were nearly all their members of parliament
- These parties have always done better among men than among women
- Often anti-feminist, and for traditional roles
- Women vote further left than men

Germany's election of February 2025: the share of men and of women who voted for each party (%)



On the other hand...



Marine Le Pen, France

Leader of the National Rally in parliament; a candidate for president in 2027



Giorgia Meloni, Italy

Leader of the Brothers of Italy; prime minister since 2022



Alice Weidel, Germany

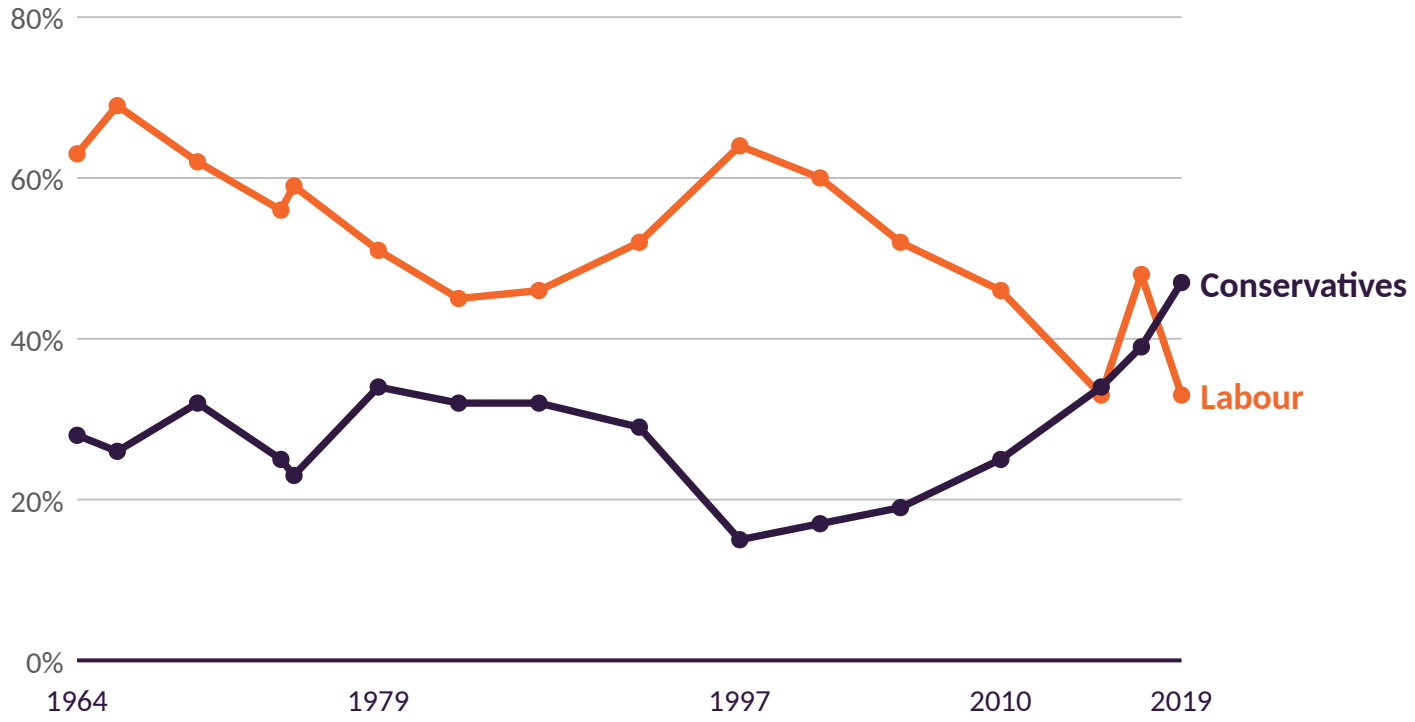
Co-leader of the AfD, re-elected in July 2026

ASK THE ROOM

Why would a radical right party want a woman at the top?

Britain’s working-class voters: did they leave Labour, or did the party leave them?

How working-class voters voted at general elections (%)



WHY THE LEFT MOVED

- Working-class voters were once a majority. In most countries they are now far from one
- Many live in safe city seats or in declining towns
- They lean left on the economy and right on social issues. Middle-class voters: the reverse
- The change is starkest under first-past-the-post

Could the left win them back with more working-class candidates?

Yes **No**

In 2019 the Conservatives led Labour among working-class voters, about 47% to 33%.

More recent waves: Moderation and Breakthrough

- In recent years, right populist parties have started to be structured more like normal parties, rather than vehicles for charismatic populist politicians
- Parties have made a serious attempt to clean up their image, kicked out most extreme and racist politicians, moved away from anti-semitism
- To some extent, this has been successful. Populist right parties have joined several governments, and their vote share has dramatically increased.

Key Points

- Populism: the pure people against the corrupt elite
- It is thin: with nativism it is right-wing, with socialism left-wing
- Its voters: people whose standing in society has slipped
- The anti-system vote is young; education sets its direction
- Since the 1990s: more polished parties, and a way into government